# Resident participation in sustainable tourism planning: evidence from coastal Kerala

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## 1. Introduction

Coastal tourism in Kerala has grown steadily over two decades, and with it the question of who decides how that growth is managed. This paper examines how residents of eleven coastal panchayats take part in tourism planning decisions.

We ask two questions. First, which residents participate, and through which channels. Second, whether participation is associated with support for further tourism development.

## 2. Methods

This is a cross-sectional household survey. We surveyed 814 households across eleven panchayats between January and April 2019, using stratified random sampling within each panchayat.

Participation was measured with a six-item scale covering attendance at planning meetings, membership of tourism committees, and written submissions. Support for tourism development was measured with four items adapted from earlier work. We also interviewed nineteen planning officers.

There was no manipulated treatment and no control group; the design is observational.

## 3. Findings

Participation was strongly associated with support for further tourism development ($r = 0.41$, $p < .001$). The association held after controlling for household income and distance from the shoreline.

Residents who had attended at least one planning meeting reported higher trust in the panchayat than those who had not. Trust in local government predicted willingness to join a tourism committee.

Participation was uneven. Households headed by women were under-represented at planning meetings, a pattern the planning officers we interviewed recognised but did not attribute to any formal barrier.

## 4. Limitations

The cross-sectional design cannot establish the direction of the association between participation and support. The sample covers one state and may not generalise.